



Instead of focusing on just rolling out services, Ambani concentrated on building a robust backend, including the sprawling Dhirubhai Ambani Knowledge City at Navi Mumbai. The strategy worked

not mind that. He, along with these couple of hundred engineers, and 15,000 others, has created a telecommunications behemoth in just 18 months. One that has more than 90 lakh subscribers, a fifth of all mobile subscribers in India; one that sells CDMA phones, where the lowest-end model has more data services than the highest-end GSM phone; one that is supported by a backend of more than Rs 15,000 crore in investments.

Enough to impress *Total Telecom*, the leading publication on telecommunications; enough for them to present him with the World Communications Award in mid-October for being the "World's Most Influential Person in Telecom."

The Dream

"The idea is to straddle the infocomm value chain," says Ambani. "We want to change the socio-economic landscape of India. We can do this by linking mobile devices and broadband services to powerful digital networks."

It is not a distant dream, nor are these words egotistic. India is already adding almost 20 lakh new mobile subscribers every month, and by the end of October, had 4.5 crore mobile subscribers. Only a few other countries, such as the US (16.5 crore) and China (a staggering 31 crore) have more mobile connections. Despite the huge growth, India's tele-density stands at a pathetic eight per cent (as against the world average of 15), making telecom giants from across the world drool: India is fast becoming the world's hottest mobile market, just behind China, which adds 40 lakh new mobile users a month.

It's Not Just About A Telephone Call

It wouldn't be exaggeration to say that it has been Ambani and his 18-month old company that have fuelled this growth. He has been able to do this by focusing on the fundamentals. In an interview with a business magazine last year, Ambani admitted that Reliance was six months late to take off (He later told *Digit*: "Yes, we were late, but when we entered, India was the most expensive telecom market in the world. Today, it is the cheapest."). However, it was also evident that Reliance was concentrating on building the backbone of India's largest and strongest fibre-optic cable network—one that spans the country.

This backbone has enabled Reliance to main-

tain a 99 per cent fault-free rate, and create the backend for more than a hundred data services on the mobile, including checking your bank account, paying your bills, booking a railway ticket, watching the latest news, and even checking your public-exam marks.

"We needed the world's most advanced technology, and the world's most advanced

network, to make this happen," says Ambani. "I believe the mobile phone

will become an information advisor, computer, entertainer, teacher, wallet, and friend in the near future. It is not long before you will be able to intelligently speak to your mobile phone to take you places. You already access video news, entertainment, and conduct m-commerce transactions."

Ambani's words are not prophetic—they are already a reality. Besides, he admits, he uses his company's R World services quite often. "I am a regular user of our broadband and data services," Ambani says with the same enthusiasm as would the owner of Rama Nayak, the famous Mumbai *Udipi* restaurant, who has a signboard put up at the entrance: "The owner of this establishment eats here." It invites a few giggles, but it also earns trust amongst the restaurant's customers.

The analogy is not bizarre. Mumbai's *Udipi* restaurants have perhaps the best delivery models in the service industry. You order, and you are served in not more than three to four minutes. A strange request, and the waiter will go to all lengths to fulfil it.

Profitability, here, depends on satisfying the customer's need.

? What Is NNOC All About?

The National Network Operating Centre (pictured on Page 27) is Reliance Infocomm's way of saying, "We have arrived." The 1.1 lakh sq ft NNOC is a single-point monitoring room that controls more than 3,000 sites and 5,000 elements. In short, the entire Reliance network of 1.2 lakh km of fibre-optic cable.

Insiders call it God—it can talk to each piece of Reliance equipment across the country; and it knows everything at all points in time.

The NNOC is divided into two sections—wireless and national/international long-distance. Since each operation is further divided into various other functions, the NNOC has teams dedicated to each—the surveillance group, the service-positioning group, traffic and capacity-routing group, performance-monitoring group, planned-events group and the applications support group. It is also one of the few such centres in the world that also records failed calls.

The 200-odd engineers here monitor the network 24x7, and everything they want to see can be visualised on the two 100 ft video walls each giving a 360-degree view of the operations. That is not surprising considering the video walls have 80 screens.

When a fault is detected, the NNOC informs the ground-level staff in the respective area. A team is then sent to the fault area, and the fault call is meant to be closed only when it is repaired. This increases accountability, and puts pressure on the ground team to keep the service fault-free.